

1450–1624

TRADING IN TREASURES

The Renaissance period was an age of expansion. Explorers setting out from Europe discovered “New” worlds in the Americas and improved sea trading routes into Asia. Now fashion became global as luxurious new commodities flooded into the West, and better transport made them available to wealthy people. Silver, gold, and cochineal beetles for dyeing made the fortune of the Spanish empire. Precious rare materials, such as aloeswood and civet glands for perfumes, and ebony wood, ivory, and ostrich feathers, became more accessible. The explosion in printing also spread knowledge to new audiences, including once-secret apothecary recipes and images of the unfamiliar, exotic inhabitants and fauna of foreign lands.



Tapestry dyes This woman, from a late 15th-century tapestry, joins flowers to create a perfumed chaplet. Her clothes are woven using the finest red dyes from Europe and the Americas to make stable reds. Under her gown she wears a shimmering cloth-of-gold lampas skirt.



Rich red and royal diamonds The world's only known diamond source during the Renaissance was Golkonda in India, and the gems were exceedingly valuable. Queen Elizabeth I, shown here, accentuated her status with copious jewellery, including two large diamonds with black backing.



Fur-lined cloaks Demand for fur sent traders to Muscovy (Russia) and Africa to source exotic pelts for European customers. With discoveries of new animals such as beaver in North America, skins for hats were shipped back across the Atlantic.



Coral beads Wealthy families prized coral, from the Mediterranean around Italy and the African coast, as a charm to protect children from illness and the evil eye. The fine quality of this girl's clothing, like that of a miniature adult, shows great expense – especially her silver and ivory rattle.